

**“From Institutional Neutrality to National Narratives: A Comparative Discourse
Analysis of UN News, Western, Middle Eastern, and Indian Media Coverage of the
Gaza Conflict (2023–2024)”**

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Abstract

This study investigates how the Gaza conflict (Oct 2023–Apr 2024) is framed across four major news systems: UN News, Western media, Middle Eastern media, and Indian media. Through qualitative thematic and discourse analysis of 60 purposively selected digital news articles, the research identifies patterns of framing, ideological positioning, and narrative flow. The study explores how institutional, geopolitical, and regional narratives differ, and how Indian media adapts, borrows, or reshapes global frames within its own journalistic and political context. By comparing neutral institutional discourse (UN News) with polarized regional narratives (Al Jazeera, Times of Israel) and global Western framing (BBC/Guardian), the research offers insights into the cross-cultural movement of conflict narratives and their transformation in Indian journalism.

Keywords: *media framing, Gaza conflict, UN News, Western media, Indian media, Al Jazeera, Times of Israel, discourse analysis, narrative adaptation.*

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Introduction

India's growing global influence and strategic diplomatic position make international conflict reporting a key component of its media ecosystem. The Israel–Palestine conflict, particularly the escalation that began in October 2023, became a major global news event, generating intense geopolitical, humanitarian, and ideological debates worldwide. As the conflict unfolded, media across different regions offered contrasting interpretations shaped by political alliances, cultural affinities, institutional mandates, and national priorities.

While Western media often approached the conflict through security-driven and geopolitical frames, Middle Eastern outlets displayed sharp narrative polarities ranging from Al Jazeera's rights-based, pro-Palestinian framing to the Times of Israel's national-security-oriented discourse. Meanwhile, UN News maintained a formally neutral and humanitarian outlook, legitimized by international law and the UN's diplomatic mandate.

Indian media, situated within a diverse and hybrid media environment, frequently synthesizes global narratives while adapting them to domestic political and cultural contexts. This study examines how Indian coverage reflects, resists, or reinterprets the framing logics of UN, Western, and Middle Eastern media.

This research aims to map the flow of narratives across these systems and identify how global frames are contextualized, translated, or transformed within Indian journalism.

Rationale

Media is a central actor in shaping public discourse on international events. In India a country with vast linguistic, cultural, and ideological diversity global conflict coverage offers a window into how international narratives are domesticated and reinterpreted. The Israel - Palestine conflict's complexity and emotional intensity make it a revealing case for studying cross-cultural media flows.

Existing research primarily examines Western media, regional Arab/Israeli media, or Indian media individually. Very few studies consider UN News as a news actor, and none compare it systematically with Indian, Western, and Middle Eastern coverage in a single framework. This research fills that gap by isolating institutional versus geopolitical versus regional versus national framings and studying how they interact.

The rationale lies in demonstrating how global discourse flows into India's media environment and how Indian outlets strategically adopt or resist narrative elements, depending on ideological alignment, national interest, or editorial stance.

Literature Review

Framing theory (Goffman, 1974; Entman, 1993) and Critical Discourse Analysis (Fairclough, 1995) form the foundational base for understanding how news organizations construct meaning during conflicts. Existing studies demonstrate that global coverage of the Israel–Palestine conflict varies sharply across regions due to political alignment, institutional mandates, and editorial priorities. Research on Western media, such as Aguiar (2010), shows consistent ideological bias and a tendency to emphasize Israeli security concerns, while Sharma (2018) notes that Indian media often replicates Western frames through wire-service dependence.

Comparative work on regional media highlights deeper polarization. Studies of Al Jazeera and Times of Israel (Doufesh & Briel, 2021) show competing humanitarian versus security-driven narratives, shaped by ethnocentric perspectives and geopolitical identity. Recent analyses of the 2023–24 conflict (Kozman & Cozma, 2024; Bhowmik & Fisher, 2023) confirm these discrepancies, with Western outlets using war-oriented frames and Middle Eastern outlets foregrounding human rights and civilian suffering. Research on institutional communication remains limited, though Muratova (2023) notes that UN News adopts a neutral, legalistic, and humanitarian tone that global media selectively use depending on their agenda.

Despite substantial work on Western, Middle Eastern, and Indian media separately, no study to date compares UN News with these three systems simultaneously or examines how Indian coverage absorbs, resists, or transforms global frames. This research fills

that gap through a structured comparative analysis of four media clusters, focusing on framing devices, ideological positioning, and narrative adaptation during the 2023–2024 Gaza conflict.

Research Objectives and Questions

Objectives

1. To analyze how the Gaza conflict is framed in UN News, Western, Middle Eastern, and Indian digital media.
2. To compare institutional, geopolitical, regional, and national framings of the same events.
3. To identify patterns of narrative flow, frame adaptation, and ideological positioning.
4. To examine how Indian media adapts, borrows, or reshapes global frames.
5. To contribute to scholarship on cross-cultural conflict communication and media globalization.

Research Questions

1. How does UN News frame the Gaza conflict compared to Western, Middle Eastern, and Indian outlets?
2. What framing devices (headlines, terminology, metaphors, tone, sources) differ across these systems?
3. How do polarized regional narratives (Al Jazeera vs Times of Israel) contrast with UN neutrality?

4. To what extent do Indian media adopt or resist Western or Middle Eastern frames?
5. What patterns of narrative translation or reframing appear during the conflict timeline?

Research Design

This study adopts a qualitative research design grounded in framing theory and Critical Discourse Analysis to compare how the Gaza conflict (Oct 2023–Apr 2024) is narrated across four media systems: UN News, Western media, Middle Eastern media, and Indian media. A purposive sample of 60 digital news articles will be analyzed. This includes 20 articles from UN News, representing institutional neutrality and humanitarian discourse; 10 articles from Western outlets such as BBC and The Guardian, reflecting global geopolitical framing; 10 articles from Middle Eastern media, equally drawn from Al Jazeera and the Times of Israel to capture polarized regional narratives; and 20 Indian articles, comprising 10 mainstream outlets (The Hindu, Indian Express, NDTV) and 10 alternative/digital outlets (The Wire, Scroll, The Print) to represent India’s diverse media landscape. To minimize sampling bias and ensure ideological diversity, the study will also use Ground News as a secondary tool for bias verification and event-based clustering, helping identify comparable articles across outlets while keeping primary analysis limited to original published texts. This sample allows the study to trace how frames move, transform, or diverge across institutional, regional, and national contexts.

The analysis will integrate thematic framing analysis with Fairclough’s Critical Discourse Analysis to examine frame categories (conflict, humanitarian, morality, responsibility), lexical and tonal patterns (e.g., “militant,” “occupation,” “hostages,” “ceasefire”), narrative structures, and source selection criteria such as reliance on UN officials, IDF statements, Hamas spokespeople, human rights organizations, diplomats,

and civilian testimonies. The study will first conduct a qualitative content analysis through systematic coding to identify recurring framing patterns, followed by Critical Discourse Analysis to interpret the ideological and narrative structures underlying those patterns. Coding and thematic extraction will be conducted using Taguette (for qualitative coding), Google Sheets (for tracking patterns, metadata, and frame frequency), and Google Docs (for analytic memo-writing and coding notes). Particular attention will be given to narrative flow: identifying how UN News' neutral discourse interacts with Western interpretations, contrasts with polarized Middle Eastern narratives, and is adapted or resisted within Indian journalism.

Ethical Considerations

This study relies exclusively on publicly accessible digital news articles and therefore involves no human participants, minimizing ethical risk. Nonetheless, the sensitive geopolitical nature of the Israel–Palestine conflict requires careful handling of terminology, quotations, and descriptions of violence. The researcher will maintain neutrality and avoid reproducing inflammatory language without contextual analysis. Since the dataset includes UN News, Western media, Middle Eastern outlets, and Indian sources each with strong ideological orientations the researcher will adopt reflexive practices throughout the coding and interpretation process to mitigate personal bias. All materials will be used within fair academic use guidelines and properly cited. No copyrighted multimedia will be reproduced beyond analytical reference. Data will be securely stored, and the research will adhere to the ethical framework of the Department of Journalism and Communication, Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda.

Limitations

The study's purposive sample of 60 articles allows for depth but may not capture the full spectrum of global reporting on the Gaza conflict. Restricting analysis to English-language articles excludes significant coverage from regional Indian and Middle Eastern vernacular media, where narratives may differ sharply. Discourse and framing analysis inherently involve interpretive subjectivity, though reflexive coding and repeated reviews aim to reduce bias. The selected timeframe (Oct 2023–Apr 2024) provides a focused snapshot but cannot represent long-term shifts in media framing as the conflict evolves. The imbalance between institutional sources (20 UN News articles) and smaller Western/Middle Eastern samples reflects the study's design priorities but may influence comparative density. Finally, as the study does not include audience research, its findings are limited to textual analysis rather than reception or impact.

Significance of the Study

This study holds substantial significance for journalism studies, media framing scholarship, and conflict communication research. By comparatively analyzing UN News, Western, Middle Eastern, and Indian media, the research fills a clear gap existing literature extensively studies Western and Middle Eastern reporting on the Gaza conflict, but almost no work examines UN News as a primary news producer or its influence on downstream media narratives. Understanding how an institutional, humanitarian-driven news outlet frames conflict is critical because UN News often positions itself as neutral, factual, and apolitical, yet still constructs narratives through selective emphasis, source choices, and discursive patterns.

The study is also valuable for understanding news flow and narrative transmission. As a budding journalist who has observed that Indian newsrooms routinely rewrite or adapt UN News reports and international wire copy, this research investigates whether similar patterns occur across global media systems. By examining how UN frames are accepted, rejected, or strategically adapted by Western, Middle Eastern, and Indian media, the study contributes to broader debates on information gatekeeping, dependence on institutional sources, and the globalization of conflict narratives. This makes the research relevant not only academically but also professionally highlighting how journalistic routines, reliance on credible institutional sources, and real-time reporting pressures shape the way international conflicts are ultimately communicated to millions of readers.

Finally, the study's insights offer practical value for journalists, editors, policy communicators, and media literacy educators. Understanding how framing shifts across geopolitical contexts can help strengthen more balanced conflict reporting, encourage critical consumption of news, and illuminate the challenges of covering politically sensitive conflicts. The research thus stands at the intersection of academic contribution and journalistic relevance, providing a nuanced understanding of how global narratives about the Gaza war are constructed, circulated, and transformed.

Tentative Timeline

Phase	Tasks	Timeline
1. Topic Refinement & Proposal Revision	Finalize narrowed topic; remove audience research; redefine research questions; confirm comparative framework	June 2025 – July 2025
2. Restart Literature Review (Post Topic Reduction)	Rebuild literature review; add framing theory, CDA, news flow theory; integrate UN News gap; reorganize thematically	September 2025 (1st–30th)
3. Introduction Revision	Rewrite introduction based on narrowed scope; strengthen rationale; refine context	September 2025 (mid–late)
4. Methodology Finalization	Finalize research design, sampling, coding tools (Taguette, Sheets), Ground News strategy, CDA framework	October 1–20, 2025

5. Article Collection & Coding	Collect 60 articles; organize metadata; conduct systematic coding; maintain frame logs	Oct 20 – Nov 30, 2025
6. Discourse Analysis	Interpret ideological patterns; compare narrative flow across UN–Western–Middle Eastern–Indian systems	December 1 – December 31, 2025
7. Findings & Discussion Chapter	Write findings; integrate coded patterns; construct comparative insights	January 1 – January 20, 2026
8. Conclusion, Significance & Implications	Draft conclusion; refine personal significance; add implications for journalism	January 20 – January 30, 2026
9. Full Draft Compilation	Format dissertation; align with MSU guidelines; finalize references; appendices	January 30 – February 7, 2026

10. Final Review & Submission Prep	Incorporate supervisor feedback; proofread; final corrections	February 7 – February 14, 2026
Final Submission	Submit the completed dissertation	February 14, 2026

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Appendix A

A1. Sampling Framework

This study uses a purposive sample of 60 digital news articles published between October 2023 and April 2024. The sample is designed to capture variation across four media systems institutional, Western, Middle Eastern, and Indian.

A1.1 Media Outlets and Sample Distribution

Media Cluster	Outlets	Articles	Purpose
UN / Institutional Media	UN News	20	Represents formally neutral, humanitarian, and legalistic reporting grounded in UN mandates.
Western Media	BBC, The Guardian	10	Reflects dominant Western geopolitical framing of the Gaza conflict.
Middle Eastern	Al Jazeera, The Times of Israel	10 (5 each)	Captures polarized rights-based versus national-security-oriented

Media			framing.
Indian Media	The Hindu, Indian Express, NDTV, The Wire, Scroll, The Print	20 (10 mainstream, 10 alternative/digital)	Represents India's diverse media ecosystem and its adaptation of global conflict narratives.

A1.2 Selection Criteria

- Articles must directly relate to the 2023–2024 Gaza conflict.
- Only straight news reports are included; opinion and editorial content are excluded.
- Articles selected to maximize thematic, tonal, and source diversity.
- Ground News is used to identify articles across political leaning (left/center/right bias ratings) and improve representativeness.

A2. Tools Used

- Taguette: primary qualitative coding tool
- Ground News: for bias comparison and article identification
- Google Sheets: metadata tracking and frame categorization
- Offline Archive: all articles stored as PDFs/HTML for auditability

